

ANALYSIS

Generative AI versus African democracies

New tech poses grave threat to our hypermediated realities

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AFRICAN democracies face an unprecedented threat as generative artificial intelligence becomes increasingly accessible. It has already been used manipulatively around recent elections. A deluge of AI-generated electoral content swept through the campaigns for the 2023 Nigerian presidential election, marking it as a turning point. Some of the 24 elections that followed across the continent in 2024 saw more of the same.

AI-generated propaganda can fundamentally undermine democratic processes which are already plagued by traditional challenges. Ahead of the Nigeria election, fake endorsements from Hollywood celebrities, former US presidents, and prominent Nigerians flooded social media. Hours before voting, AI-generated audio clips circulated, purportedly revealing candidates' plans to rig the vote.

Ahead of South Africa's 2024 election, AI-generated videos popped up, including a deepfake speech by then-

US president Joe Biden threatening sanctions on the country if the ruling ANC party won.

AI propaganda has also been linked to military coups on the continent – before, during and after they occur.

Trying to counter public speculation that Gabon's then President Ali Bongo was too unwell to govern, his team released a video purporting to show him giving his 2018 State of the Nation address. "His" expressions in the video stood out for being unnaturally stiff, raising further questions about his fitness to rule and triggering a failed coup attempt in 2019.

In Burkina Faso, AI-generated content became something of a political staple following the September 2022 coup by Captain Ibrahim Traoré.

Right after the coup, AI-generated videos showing purported "American Pan-Africanists" expressing support for the new military regime circulated widely on social media. In recent months, propaganda videos have depicted Traoré making critical speeches – in English, which he is not known to speak fluently.

The Africa Centre for Strategic Studies, a project of the US Defense Department, claims that 6 in 10 disinformation campaigns targeting Africa are foreign-sponsored, primarily by Russia, China, and Gulf states, and that West Africa has borne the brunt of them in recent years.

To date, African authorities and campaigners have largely relied on two mechanisms to counter this deluge of

manipulative content: encouraging self-policing from social media platforms, and fact-checking by a handful of groups and media outlets. Both are insufficient.

Social media platforms' safeguards, designed primarily for dominant languages like English, leave gaping holes in protection for African users and others across Global Majority countries. Even for languages that are safeguarded, measures employed by social media companies – such as forwarding limits and collaboratively labelling misleading posts – are easily circumvented.

Fact-checking – by organisations like Africa Check, Dubawa in Nigeria, and PesaCheck in Kenya – is a manual, time-intensive process that cannot match the speed at which AI-generated content spreads. Large tech companies like Meta, which could do it at a large scale, are deprioritising fact-checking.

How to roll back the fakes

This crisis will require co-ordinated pan-African action across three key areas: citizen education, regulation and technical solutions.

Citizen education on AI must expand fast. Governments and civil society must develop accessible programmes to train more people, particularly those with limited digital literacy, in identifying AI-generated content.

Regulatory frameworks must get stronger and continental. While 38 of 54 African countries have enacted data protection laws, comprehensive frameworks specifically addressing generative AI remain lacking.

Given the reports that most disinformation campaigns in Africa are foreign-sponsored, African nations must work together to identify and counter these sponsors and their agendas. This includes sharing intelligence, co-ordinating responses, and developing continental standards for AI governance.

Third, investing in technical solutions. African governments must support the development of AI detection tools tailored to local languages and cultural contexts. Current AI-assisted fact-checking systems, trained primarily on Western data, often fail to understand African cultural nuances and may misidentify legitimate content as disinformation, along with the inverse.

As these technologies become more sophisticated and accessible, their threat to credible democracy will only intensify. Success against this challenge will necessitate unprecedented cooperation between governments, civil society, academia, and technology companies. They must act now or the window for proactive action will close.

The cost of inaction will be backsliding on democracy, increased political instability, and further erosion of public trust – losses which far exceed the investment needed to build robust defences against AI-generated disinformation and propaganda. ■



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